

Market Research

Arrival — trip-scoped language preparation

Kevin Francisco · September 2026

Headline finding

This product has been built before, and it left the consumer market. TripLingo, founded 2011, was a travel-first language app offering phrases across formality levels, offline audio, culture briefings, and voice translation. It raised roughly \$2M and was acquired in April 2019 by Travel and Transport, a corporate travel management company, which folded it into its Dash Mobile platform for duty-of-care and cost-savings use. The consumer Android app was unpublished from Google Play in December 2021 with a 3.26 rating across 290 ratings.

The category winner did not lose to Duolingo. It found that the durable buyer was an enterprise, not a traveler. That finding shapes every recommendation in this document.

Method

Desk research across app store listings and reviews, travel forums (Fodor's), language-learning blogs and review sites, company and funding databases (PitchBook, Tracxn), trade press (PhocusWire), and published market sizing. Sources are listed on the final page.

Competitive landscape

Product	Model / price	Strength	Gap for this use case
Duolingo	Free, paid tiers. \$1.04B FY2025 revenue, up 39%; 12.2M paid subscribers; ~71% of category in-app purchase revenue.	Habit formation, brand default. Max tier adds AI roleplay for real-life situations.	Open-ended curriculum with no concept of a departure date. Widely criticized for teaching sentence construction rather than communication.
Babbel	~\$8.97/mo on annual plan, \$299 lifetime. One language per subscription.	Structured, practical dialogue written by linguists.	No trip scoping. Per-language subscription is the wrong shape for a single-trip user.
Mondly	~\$10/mo or ~\$62/yr. 41 languages.	Closest major to travel-first. 5-10 minute lessons on practical everyday vocabulary; dedicated Travel topic; strong on restaurant, hotel, transport.	Rigid answer matching (correct alternatives marked wrong). Still a general course, not a trip plan.

Product	Model / price	Strength	Gap for this use case
Memrise	Freemium subscription.	Native-speaker video clips; scenario courses for travel; MemBot AI chat for rehearsal.	Scenarios are generic templates, not derived from the user's actual trip.
Google Translate	Free.	What travelers actually use. Zero pre-trip effort.	Solves in-the-moment lookup, not preparation or confidence.
ChatGPT and custom GPTs	Free to ~\$15/mo.	Paid custom GPTs already market a placement test, a custom roadmap to a travel goal, spaced-repetition vocabulary, and speaking simulations.	Cannot hold a schedule across sessions or time retention to a date. This is the substitute to beat, not Duolingo.
Phrasebook app long tail	Free with IAP.	Offline, cheap, abundant.	Scanning the App Store, most have too few ratings to display a score. The shallow version of this idea is already free and undifferentiated.

Recurring user pain points

Everything is built for fluency, I have six weeks

Stated directly and unprompted on the Fodor's travel forums: a traveler planning a month in Spain, with two months to prepare, said the available language programs felt too general for their needs. This is the product thesis in a stranger's words.

The content is wrong, not just slow

The sharpest critique of the category is that it teaches sentence construction while missing the actual objective, which is sending and receiving critical information. Learners report working through a course for a long time and still being unable to speak a sentence while traveling.

They can ask, but cannot understand the answer

The most under-served pain in the category. Every phrasebook trains production. None train receiving the reply at native speed.

Forgetting

Even well-reviewed AI apps lack spaced repetition or long-term vocabulary tracking. Nothing times recall to a date.

The "I'll pick it up there" fallacy

Travelers report arriving with phrasebooks expecting to absorb the language, then defaulting to English and Google Translate because real conversations move too fast.

Nobody knows what to prioritize

The counterpoint on that same forum thread: you do not know which phrases are essential until you are standing in the situation. This is the objection the regret corpus is designed to answer.

Unmet needs

- **Deadline-aware curriculum.** No product takes a departure date as an input. Reviewer roundups still triage this manually, telling users to pick one app if the trip is a year out and another if it is next week.
- **Comprehension training** for the three or four replies a ticket agent will actually give.
- **Situation rehearsal tied to a real itinerary**, not a generic restaurant.
- **A “good enough to be understood” pronunciation bar**, rather than scoring against native accuracy.
- **High-stakes coverage.** Travelers consistently name dietary needs, allergies, medical, and emergency phrasing as the real reason to prepare.
- **Trip-shaped pricing.** One trip, one price, not a subscription to a language.

Differentiation

Two things, and only two.

1. The scheduler is the product

Framed as constrained optimization rather than curriculum: given N days until departure, M minutes per day, and a trip profile, select the highest-expected-value items and sequence the spaced repetition so peak recall lands on the trip dates rather than trailing off indefinitely. No competitor schedules retention against a future event. It is also the one thing a general-purpose chatbot cannot hold across sessions.

2. The regret corpus

“Travelers who went to Kyoto wished they had known how to ask X” is a ranking signal, a marketing hook, and the only proprietary data asset available in this category. It also directly answers the “you don’t know what matters until you’re there” objection: let the people who were already there rank it.

Everything else — audio, offline, roleplay, culture notes — is table stakes that TripLingo shipped a decade ago.

Market context

- Global language learning apps market: ~\$6.34B in 2024, projected to \$24.39B by 2033 (~16% CAGR). Standalone mobile app revenue, the portion consumers actually pay into, was ~\$1.11B, about 15% of the total.
- Duolingo took roughly 71% of monthly in-app purchase revenue among language apps as of July 2024, and crossed \$1B in annual revenue in 2025.
- Category downloads held above 300M for a second consecutive year, and AI-powered features are now table stakes rather than a differentiator.

- Duolingo cut monthly churn from ~47% in 2020 to ~28% in core markets by 2026 through heavy gamification investment, against an open-ended fluency goal.

Assessment

As a standalone consumer subscription: weak

- The usage window is one trip. The product churns users by design.
- Acquisition must catch users inside a narrow pre-trip window, which makes CAC expensive against a lifetime value of roughly one purchase.
- The category is a monopoly with a long free tail.
- ChatGPT does most of this for free, and the paid prompt-pack market for it already exists.
- TripLingo ran this exact experiment for eight years and exited into corporate travel.

Where it is compelling

- **As a portfolio piece.** It demonstrates constraint-based product thinking, a real prioritization algorithm, and a defensible wedge.
- **As an embedded feature.** Booking platforms, tour operators, travel insurers, and corporate travel programs all want pre-trip engagement and duty-of-care coverage. That is the path TripLingo took, and it worked.
- **As a module inside Hindsight,** reusing one corpus and one acquisition funnel instead of building two of each.

Recommendation. Build the MVP as a demonstration of the scheduling engine. Do not position it as a standalone business. If it gets traction, the interesting question is whether it belongs inside Hindsight rather than beside it.

Sources

- PitchBook and Tracxn company profiles, TripLingo
- PhocusWire and PRWeb, Travel and Transport acquisition of TripLingo, 2019
- AppBrain, TripLingo Google Play listing history
- Fodor's Travel Talk Forums, Europe board, language app thread
- Apple App Store listings and reviews: Mondly, Memrise, and travel phrasebook apps
- Duolingo FY2025 results and investor communications; Sensor Tower churn analysis
- Straits Research and LingoBright, language learning apps market sizing
- Langoly, ICanLearn, PolyChat, and LanguaTalk product reviews and roundups